years that he was prime minister, he wrote letters every fortnight to the chief ministers of each of India's states. In each letter, he described in detail not only his key domestic policy decisions but also explained the context of those decisions. The letters also provided details about every foreign visit by the prime minister, visits by foreign dignitaries to India and included details of what was discussed.

Through these letters, Nehru hoped to educate his chief ministers about domestic as well as world affairs. Thus, his letters explained developments like the merger between Egypt and Syria resulting in the creation of the United Arab Republic or Indonesia's domestic troubles of March 1958.[13] 'We in India cannot cut ourselves off from this world situation and have to play our part in it whenever occasion demands it,' [14] he wrote in another. In his view, India had 'built up some kind of a reputation the world over and we are respected even by those who do not agree with us'.[15]

For him, the fortnightly letters were part of his effort to build the new state, offering and seeking advice with the second tier of Indian leaders. The tradition began and ended with Nehru as his successors had neither the interest nor the patience to act as teachers for other politicians. His interest in the minutest of details is reflected in one of the letters he wrote to his chief ministers in which he talks about the need to change the height of the broom used to sweep floors to improve both its efficiency as well as to ensure that the person using it did not face any health problems.[16]

Critics read into Nehru's letters, speeches and writings a reflection of his personal loneliness and his desire to find company and solace in the people of India who were under his care.[17] But Nehru sought to lead India into the world beyond the subcontinent through his books, letters and speeches. He was perhaps more concerned about India's historical tendency to insulate itself from the world beyond than to ease personal loneliness by connecting to Indians at the grass roots. His letters and speeches reflect his anguish at international conflict, his fervent desire that others see the world and India